



Design Document for:

TIMELESS

The key to the past lies in the future

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Version # 0.1

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Design History

The following section will enumerate the game's updates and changes over the course of the development phase. It aims to provide a solid comprehension of the state of the game during its development and the path it followed to arrive at its final state.

Version 0.1

Version 0.1 is the initial version of the game and includes:

1. The game's main mechanics. (Time traveling; movement)
2. 2 levels for the user to get accustomed to the game.

Game Overview

Philosophy

Philosophical point #1

Timeless aims to be a standout, featuring (and centering) its main game mechanic, that is, time travel, on something rarely seen across the game market.

I believe this feature, in and of itself, is enough to bring attention to this game. Later on, winning over all those curious enough to try it with the way all mechanics and levels are implemented/designed.

Philosophical point #2

I choose to keep this game PC only, not only because it is an easier media to build, and publish, games to, but also because it features the highest percentage of hardcore gamers (per the hardcore-casual gamer model).

Philosophical point #3

The core philosophy of Timeless is to challenge players through a fusion of obstacles: puzzles, enemies, and the dynamic interaction between them. The game is designed so that neither puzzles nor enemies, in isolation, represent the sole challenge; instead, the player's primary struggle emerges from confronting the combination of these two elements.

Common Questions

What is the game?

Timeless is a puzzle-platformer that follows Jack Cooper, a subject of time manipulation experiments that led him to be able to travel back and forth in time. This narrative is interwoven with the game's mechanics by allowing the player the ability to move across different points in time to pass challenges (puzzles, obstacles, enemies, etc) and, ultimately, reach the end of the game.

Why create this game?

I am creating this game to fill a big hole in the game market related to time travel. Apart from some examples here and there (Notably Chrono Trigger, and one specific section in TitanFall 2), there is a big lack of time traveling games that have had big public attention. Timeless aims to be the one to break this tendency.

Where does the game take place?

Timeless is set in the fictional city of Vox. Originally a humble, small city, Vox rapidly gained popularity and subsequently transformed into a sprawling dystopia almost overnight. The game will present players with both phases of the city's history, as the environment, due to time, shift between areas of small, charming houses and towering, brutalist architectural structures.

What do I control?

The player controls Jack Cooper, a subject of time manipulation experiments that led him to be able to travel back and forth in time. Initially Jack Cooper will reject this power and hate his newfound abilities, but as time goes on and danger lurks near, Jack may be forced to adapt, or die.

How many characters do I control?

Não aplicável

What is the main focus?

The game's main focus follows the journey of Jack Cooper across multiple different environments as he hunts for answers to what happened to him, and revenge.

What's different?

This game is different from other puzzle-platformers as it implements a central new game mechanic not really known to the market right now, that mechanic being the ability for the player to travel between points in time to solve puzzles.

Feature Set

General Features

Over 50 level on game release
Pixel art based design

Multiplayer Features

Não Aplicável

Editor

Não aplicável

Gameplay

Time Travel mechanics
Fast and addictive movement system
Combat across different points in time
Various types of enemies

The Game World

Overview

The game is set in the fictional city of Vox, in both its early start, and dystopian eras. The rest of the world will not really be of great importance to the game's narrative, but might be included in a few small references.

Small city by day...

Vox started out as most cities do, not really being a city at all. Most citizens lived rural lives and those that didn't opted for a relatively humble and normal urban life near the "heart" of the city.

Business was mostly agrarian, houses were big, and population was small.

On the world stage, Vox was barely considered, and most people hadn't even heard about it.

... Big dystopia by night.

However, it all changed in the blink of an eye. People started pouring into the city and business was booming. The sudden high demand for living the city generated, forced its hand in creating fast and reproducible solutions to its housing crisis. These solutions came in the form of bleak and block-like apartment buildings, big and imposing industry districts, and dark shades of grey all throughout.

Vox didn't want to become what it did. It was forced. And this fact is visible just by batting an eye over the city.

The Lab.

In the surrounding mountains of vox lies, under the ground and hidden from prying eyes, a laboratory focused on unraveling the mystery that is time.

In the past, this laboratory will be like any other lab, bright, white, and shiny all over. But in the present, the story changes, and due to an unknown circumstance, the lab finds itself mostly destroyed, with rubble everywhere, raiders and animals out and about, and nature starting to take back what is rightfully hers.

The Physical World

Overview

The physical world is either composed of small houses, small buildings, and lively colours, or big block buildings, lots of pollution and degradation, and shades of gray.

Key Locations

- The city of Vox, composed of a small humble town in the past, and a brutalistic dystopia in the future.
- The surrounding mountains, mostly unchanged between the past and the future, and composed of tall, grass-top mountains with lots of trees.
- The lab, where the game's journey begins. Bleak and heartless. Mostly composed of shades of white, with little to no decoration.

Travel

Most traveling will be done on foot, and big changes in location will usually not be included in gameplay sequences.

Scale

The game's scale will change throughout the game, initially being small and claustrophobic, due to the lab's environment. And later on making the player feel tiny compared to the monolithic brutalist structures that the dystopic Vox presents.

Objects

Objects will be placed to appropriately match their environment.

For example:

- Lab: Monitors, syringes, ceiling lights, computers, and vials.
- City: Newspapers, phones, trash, benches, and streetlights.

Weather

The weather will be nonexistent inside the lab.

In the city, the weather will be calm and sunny in the past, and rainy and dark in the present.

Day and Night

The game's progression will feature changes in the time of day between levels, but this will be handled in a straightforward, empirical manner. There is no need for a complex day-night cycle system.

Time

Time will be the main focus of the game. It will follow the normal rules of time if the player so desires it, but can be regressed or advanced with a simple hit of a button.

A key feature is that time progresses independently across different periods. When the player is in the past, the future continues to advance, and vice-versa. Enemies in the non-active timeline will also continue their movements and actions despite the player's absence.

Rendering System

Overview

The game will be rendered in 2D. The player is the center of reference and will measure 32 pixels tall when standing still.

2D/3D Rendering

Timeless will use the Godot™ 2D rendering engine.

Camera

Overview

The camera will, generally, follow the player around as he moves in the scenery.

Camera Detail #1

When the player decides to time travel, the camera will be flooded with an intense flashing white background, and be teleported, along with the player, to the different time section of the level.

Camera Detail #2

The camera will employ a "soft follow" or "lagging" mechanism. Instead of instantly centering the player, the camera will maintain a central-ish field of view, allowing the main character a moderate amount of movement freedom within the screen without the camera immediately panning to keep them centered. The camera will only begin to follow when the player approaches the edges of this central "breathing room".

Game Engine

Overview

The game engine used by Timeless will be the Godot™ game engine.

Water

Não aplicável

Collision Detection

Não aplicável.

Lighting Models

Overview

Timeless will use the Godot™ Lighting model.

Lighting Model Detail #1

In some circumstances, lighting will be baked directly on to the game's assets at the time of creation.

The World Layout

Overview

The game world is structured into distinct levels. Within the initial lab environment, a level is defined by a succession of interconnected rooms. When the setting transitions to the city, the levels will be designed to maintain a consistent, average completion time.

Game Characters

Overview

Jack Cooper is an adult male victim of lab experiments that left him with a robotic arm and spine. Due to these experiments, he also became able to travel back and forth in time.

Creating a Character

Não aplicável

Enemies and Monsters

Enemies will vary depending on the environment and point in time the player is at. For example, in the beginning lab levels, if the player finds himself in the past, he will be facing mostly lab staff and guards, but in the present, his enemies will likely be animals and raiders looking to loot the rundown lab.

User Interface

Overview

The User Interface will try to keep itself simple, not only to reduce production time, but also to keep the player as immersed as possible into the story and environment of the game.

Damage and health

To keep the players as immersed and aware as possible, all damage will be fatal, this means there is no need for elements like a health bar, or other more advanced solution of displaying damage.

Movement

As the game is PC only, all movement will be done through a keyboard, thus keeping the interface free of movement controls.

Time State Indicator Policy

To uphold the principle of immersion, the game will intentionally omit any dedicated User Interface element indicating the current time state. Players will instead be required to actively observe and analyze their environment and surroundings to discern their position in time.

Weapons

Overview

To introduce game mechanics one at a time, the player will initially be free of any weapons, being forced to avoid all enemies and potentially fatal obstacles. Later on in the game though, the player will be surprised with the fact he had a weapon all along in the shape of an electric blade that extends from the upper wrist area of his robotic arm.

Attacking and its combination with movement

Attacks will be quick and feature a “combo” mechanic where, if done in close succession to one another, attack will flow from the previous attack, combining animations and making attacks feel less boring.

Attacks will also be able to be done in multiple states, either while standing still, while in the middle of the air, while jumping, and even while dashing.

Musical Scores and Sound Effects

Overview

As of version 0.1, no sound effects or musical scores have been implemented. It is however planned for the game to have both of these features on full release.

Red Book Audio

Não aplicável

3D Sound

Não Aplicável

Sound Design

The game's sound design will prioritize realism, utilizing readily available free online assets rather than custom-created audio.

Single-Player Game

Overview

Timeless will focus itself on being a Single-Player only experience. The player will traverse various levels set in different environments, while solving any puzzles and eliminating/avoiding any enemies in his path. The game will also be heavily narrative driven, presenting the story of Jack Cooper, the lab experiment turned Time Traveling revenge seeker.

The story will be mostly presented to the player through dialog present in dialog boxes and cutscenes.

Story

The narrative of Timeless opens with Jack Cooper, a test subject who has gained time manipulation powers following unethical experimentation. The story immediately sees Jack escaping the laboratory where he was held, fighting both monstrous enemies and lab personnel as he learns to control his new abilities.

Upon escaping the facility, Jack finds himself in a contrasting setting: the natural environment of mountains near the town of Vox. Vox serves as a significant contrast, being a humble settlement in the past, but a large, dystopian, and 'soulless' metropolis in the present.

The story then shifts focus to Jack's efforts to assimilate into the present-day city while pursuing those responsible for the experiments. In the present, Jack is constantly exposed to advertisements for Voxtech products. These ads subtly foreshadow a major revelation: the founder of Voxtech is the same individual behind the time manipulation experiments. The ads strongly suggest that the widespread success of VoxTech and the prosperity of the present-day city of Vox are directly attributable to the unethical research conducted on subjects like Jack.

The middle portion of the game will emphasize the widespread benefits VoxTech has brought to society, highlighting applications across medicine, entertainment, and transportation, which Jack will be reminded of frequently.

As the game nears its climax, Jack closes in on the perpetrator. This confrontation culminates in a moral dilemma for the player: Jack must choose between two outcomes: exacting revenge by killing the man, or forgiving him after acknowledging the considerable societal good that ultimately resulted from his unethical experiments.

Hours of Gameplay

I believe the game is aiming for about 5 to 10 hours of gameplay, enough to present the story calmly to the player but also not so long it becomes boring.

Victory Conditions

Level-wise: By beating the level and solving its platforming puzzles.

Game-wise: By reaching the end of the game.

Multiplayer Game

Overview

Não Aplicável

Max Players

Não Aplicável

Servers

Não Aplicável

Customization

Não Aplicável

Internet

Não Aplicável

Gaming Sites

Não Aplicável

Persistence

Não Aplicável

Saving and Loading

Não Aplicável.

Character Rendering

Overview

Jack will be a white character with a robotic spine and arm, the latter of which he hides under a dark green cloak akin to a poncho he stole from a lab looter in the present. His design will be similar to designs from games like Hollow Knight and Ori and the Blind Forest. The game will follow a pixel art theme with Jack being exactly 32 bits tall while standing still.

World Editing

Overview

Não Aplicável

Extra Miscellaneous Stuff

Overview

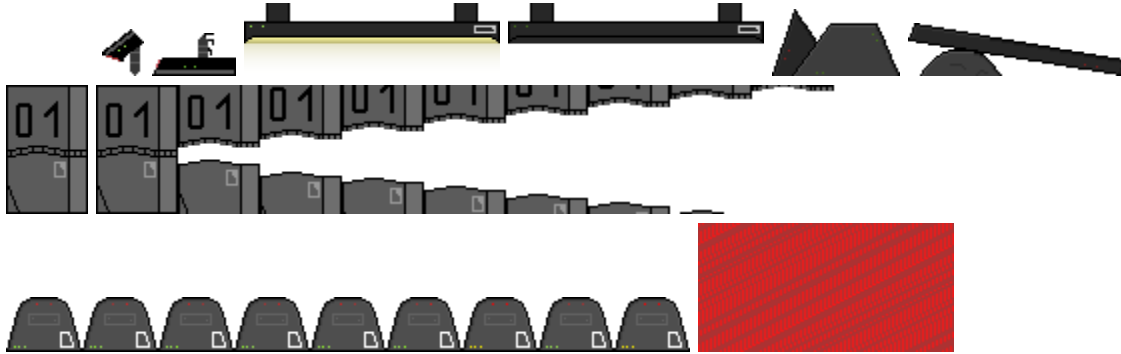
Não Aplicável

Junk I am working on...

Não Aplicável

“Objects Appendix”

The following appendix will display the various object assets present in the game’s current state (V0.1).



“Character Rendering and Animation Appendix”

The following appendix will display the various renders and animation frames of the main character in the current state of the game (V0.1).

